

GPU Architectures



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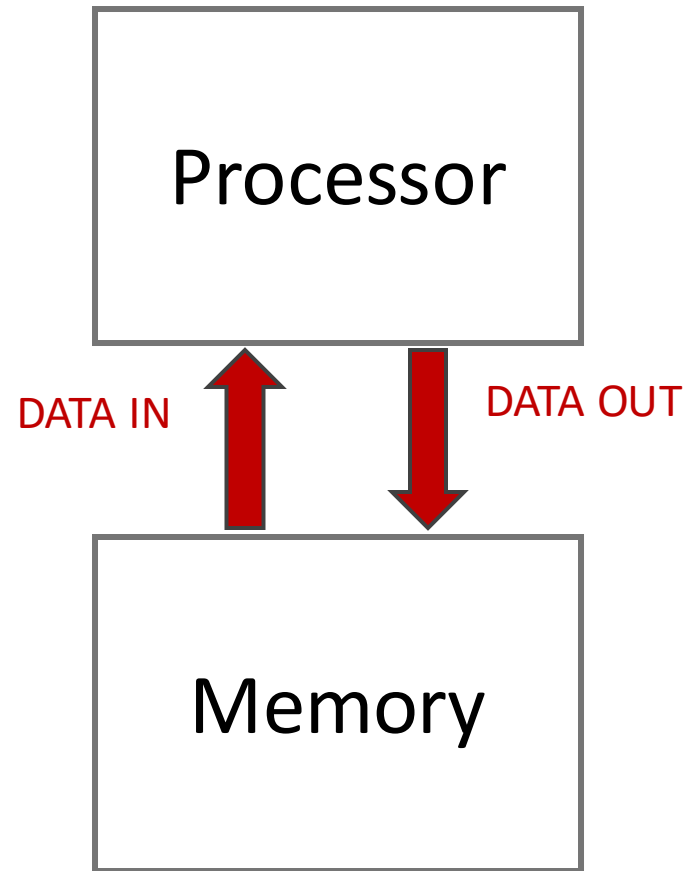
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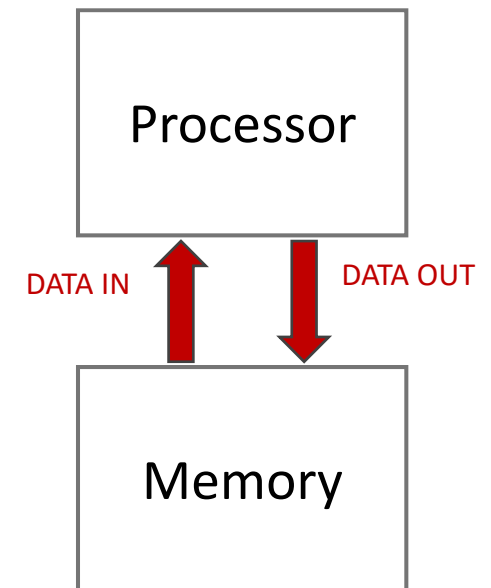
A Simple Model of Performance



A Simple Model of Performance

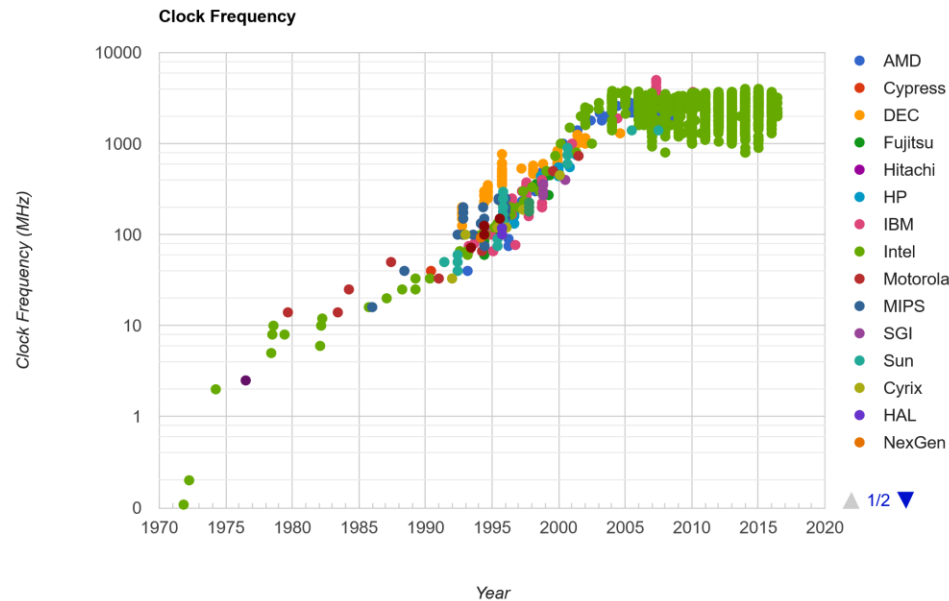
A number of factors affect the performance of the model:

- **Clock speed:** the rate of issue of instructions by the processor
- **Memory latency:** time taken to retrieve a data item from memory
- **Memory bandwidth:** amount of data transferred in unit time
- **Parallelism:** can I replicate the basic processing unit?



CPU Clock Speed

- Clock speed has plateaued since the early 2000s.
- This is primarily due to power limits being reached.



Andrew Danowitz, Kyle Kelley, James Mao, John P. Stevenson, and Mark Horowitz. 2012. CPU DB: recording microprocessor history. *Commun. ACM* 55, 4 (April 2012), 55–63. <https://doi.org/10.1145/2133806.2133822>

Latency

- Retrieving data from RAM can take $O(100-1000)$ clock cycles
- CPUs reduce the impact of this using cache hierarchy

Bandwidth

- Size $O(100)$ GB, bandwidth $O(100)$ GB/second
- Often bottleneck

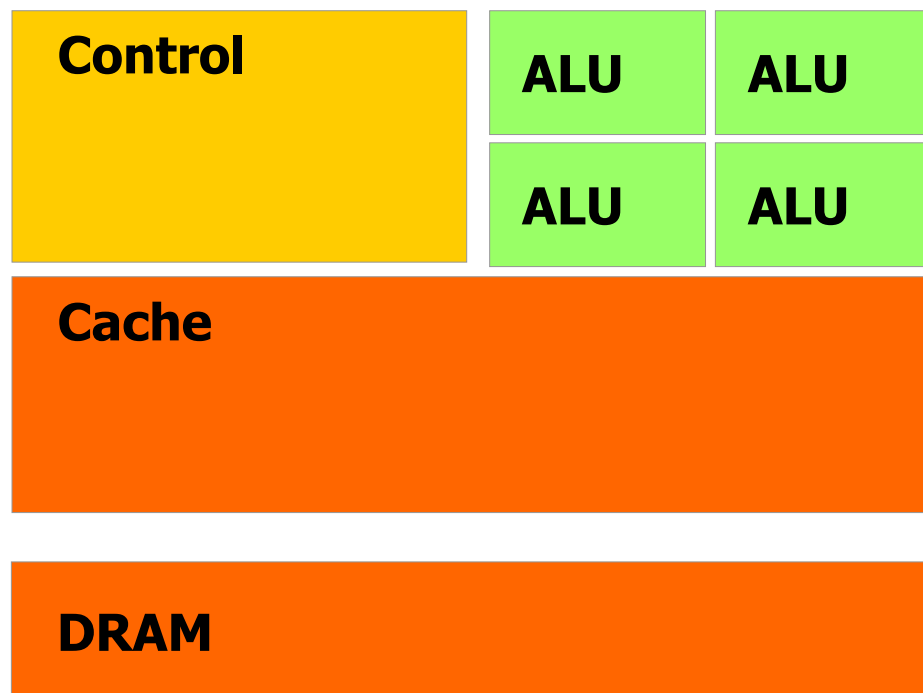
CPU Parallelism



- Multi-core systems
- Applications must be parallel (MPI, OpenMP, threading etc)

CPU vs GPU Hardware

- Much more area dedicated to compute



CPU

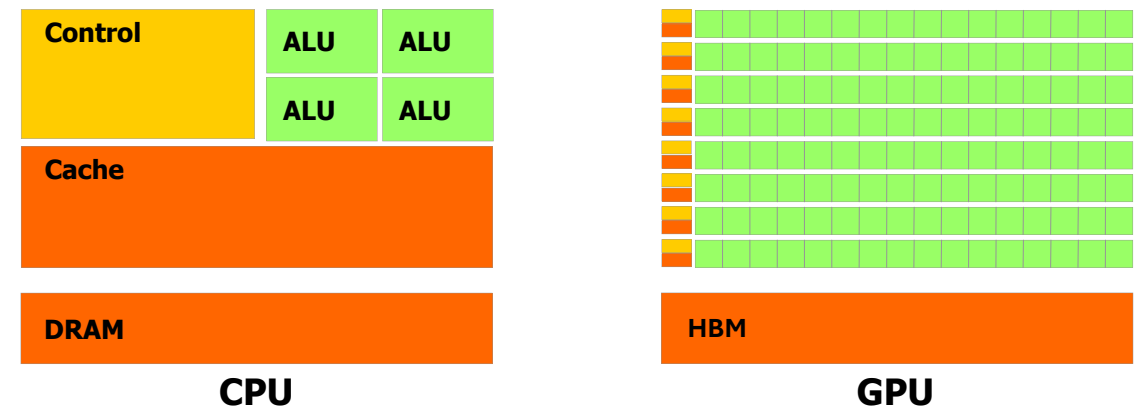


GPU

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CPU vs GPU Hardware

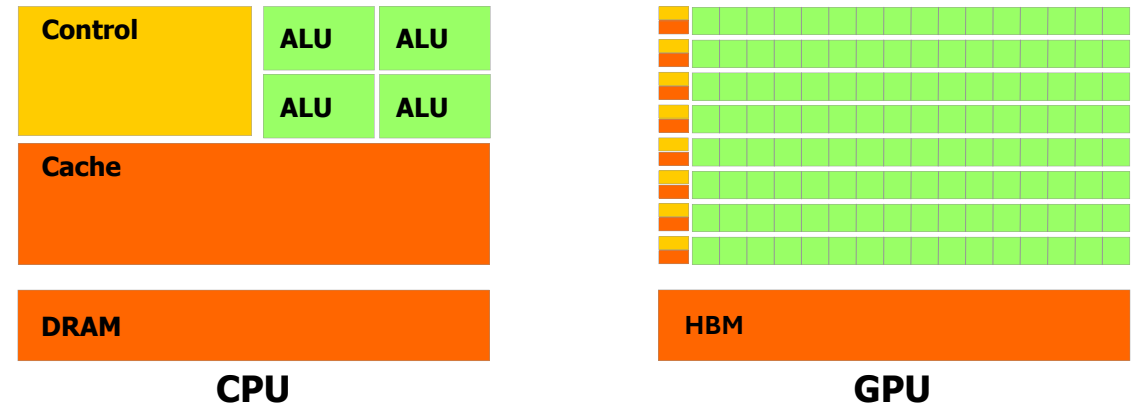
- CPU computational units are “bigger” but smaller in number
- CPU cores are faster and “smarter” than a GPU core
 - E.g. out-of-order executions, branch prediction, speculative execution
- GPUs specialise in floating point operations:
 - E.g. multiply-add, fused multiply-add, tensor core, ray tracing core
- Performance of a GPU does not come from the processing capabilities of individual cores, rather the massive parallelism



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CPU vs GPU Hardware

- GPUs have high bandwidth, but high latency .
- Hide latency with multiple threads and fast switching contexts
 - more software threads than physical cores



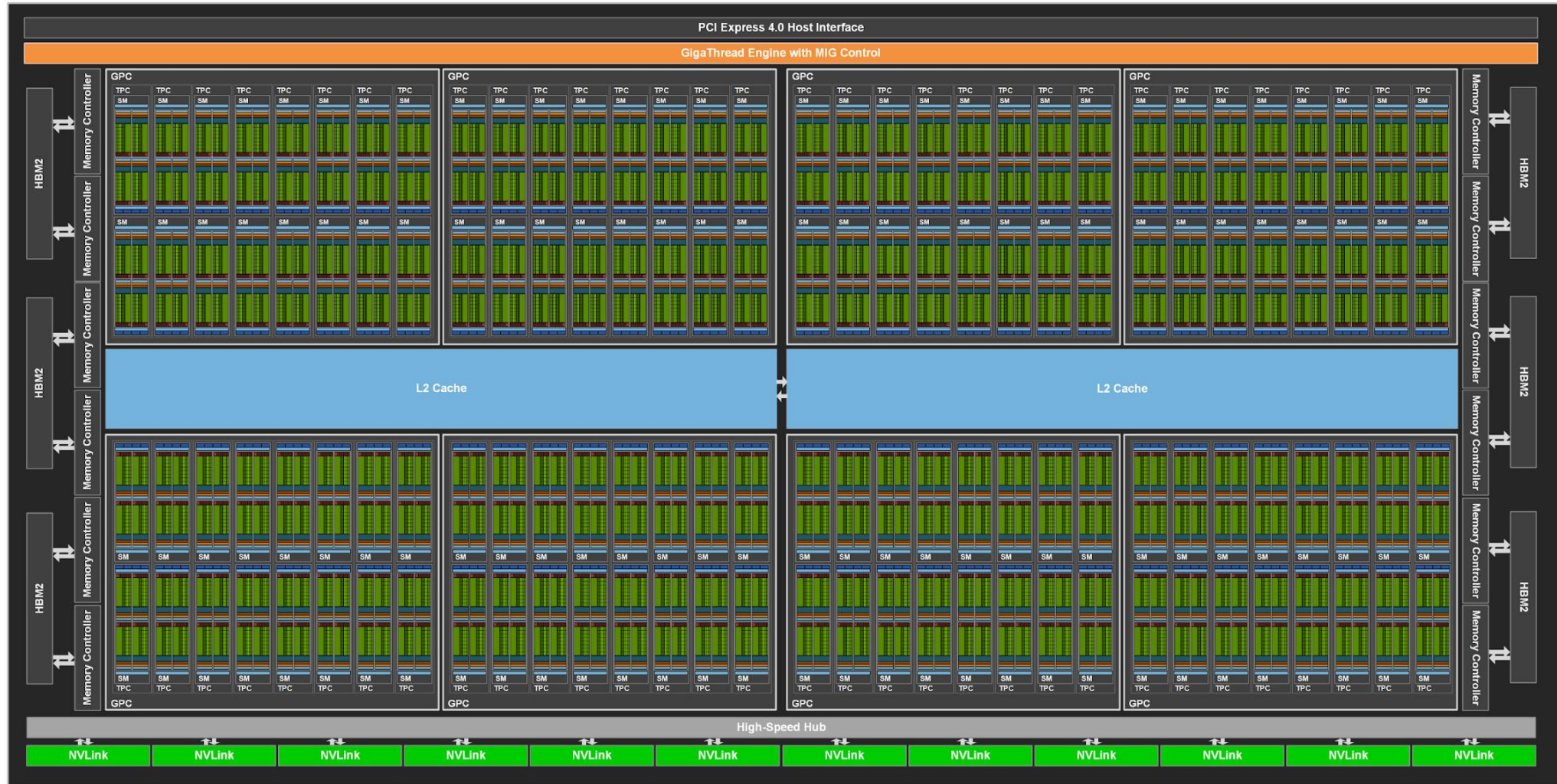
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Single Instruction Multiple Data (SIMD)

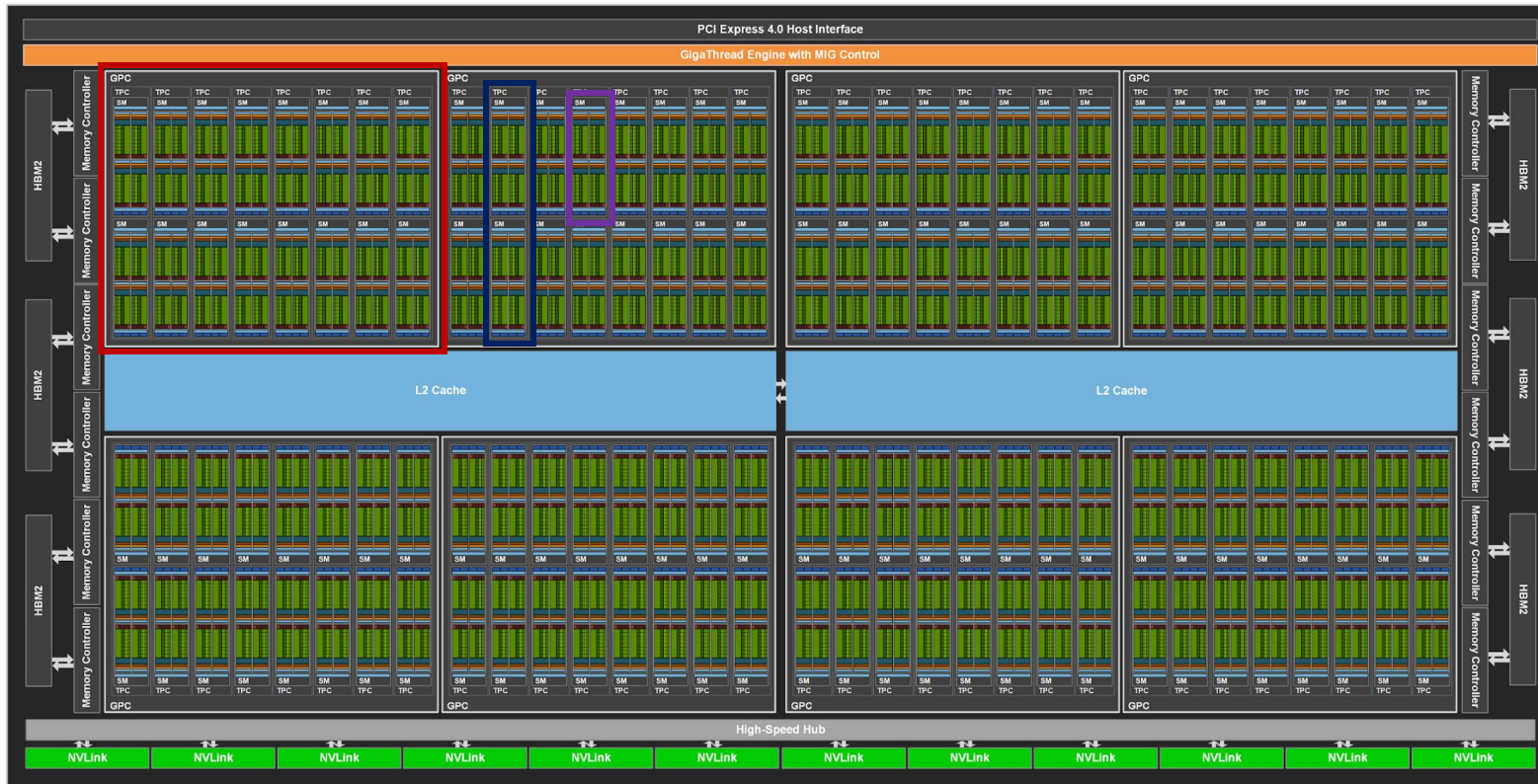


- All the GPU cores execute exactly the same operation, but over different data.
- Rather than N clock steps to process N data points, N compute units process N data points in a single clock step (if sufficient cores).
- SIMD is effective for many applications:
 - Computer graphics – a single operation/series of operations needs applying to all pixels in an image.
 - Training AI models – input data in the same batch can be processed in parallel
 - Scientific simulation – many algorithms can be parallelised.

GPU Structure – NVIDIA A100



GPU Structure – NVIDIA A100



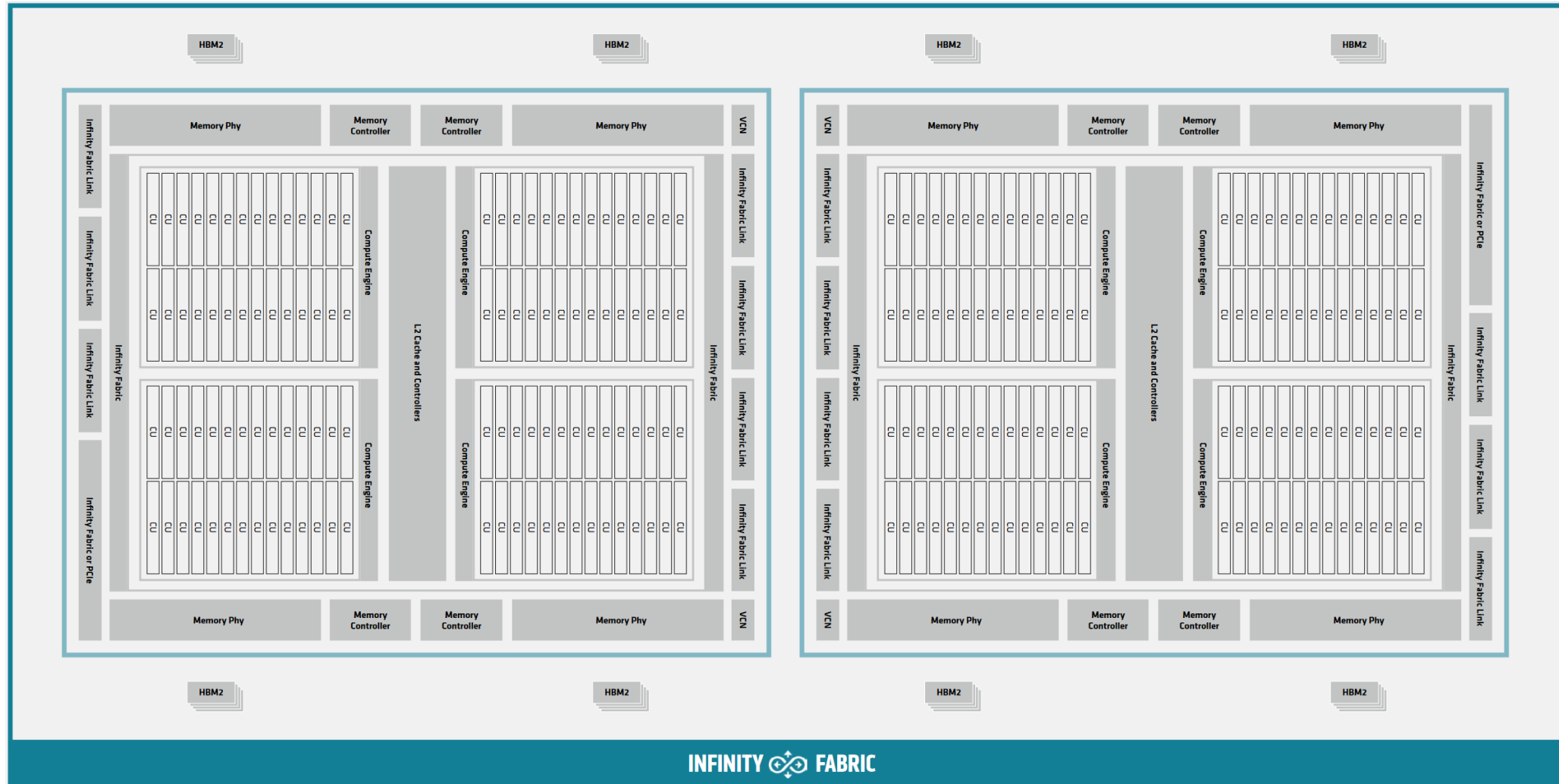
- GPU Processing Cluster (GPC)
- Texture Processing Cluster (TPC)
- Streaming Multiprocessor (SM)

GPU Structure – NVIDIA A100



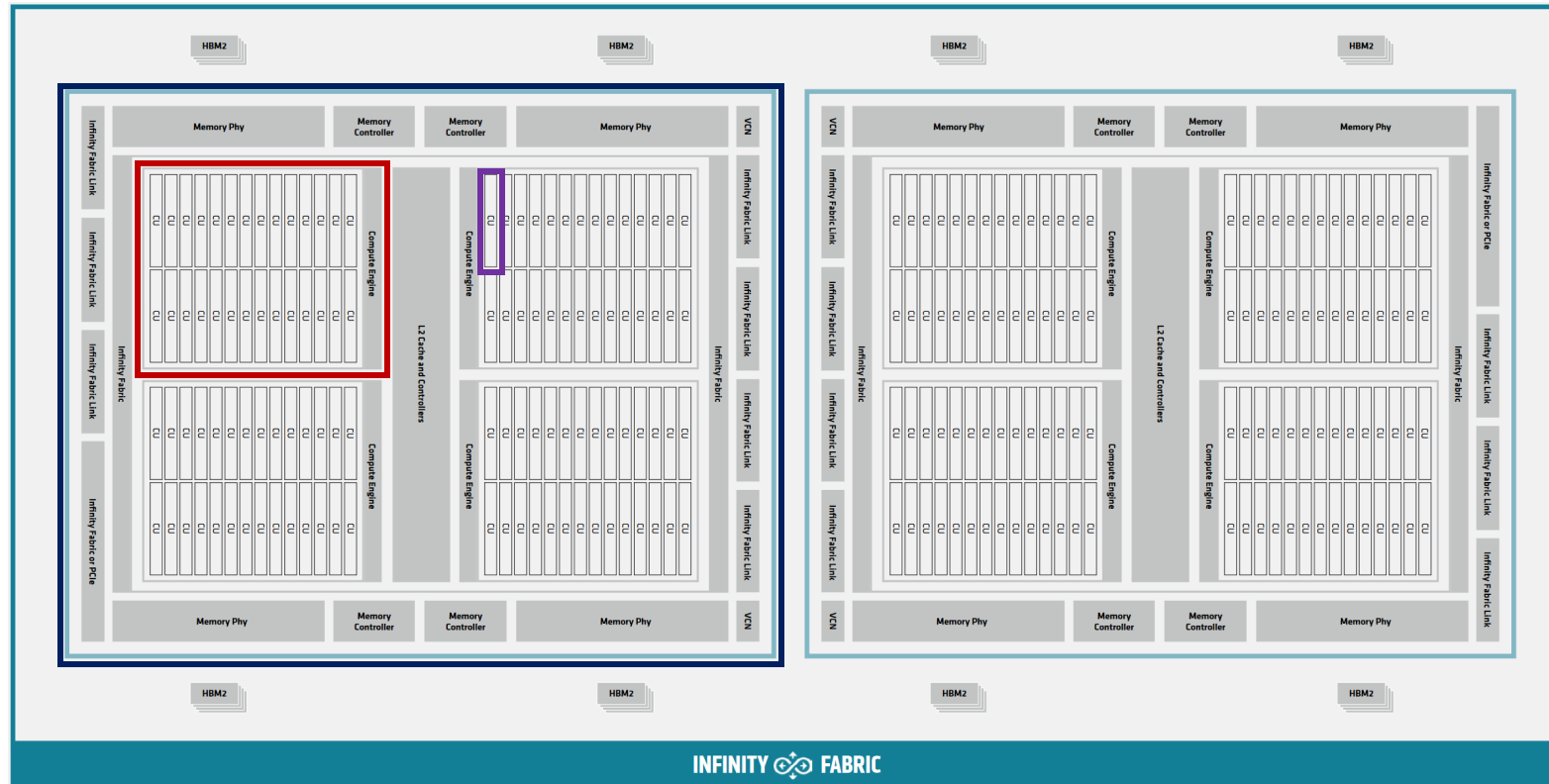
- Each SM is subdivided into 4 processing blocks.
- This allows for greater flexibility in scheduling.

GPU Structure – AMD MI200



<https://www.amd.com/content/dam/amd/en/documents/instinct-business-docs/white-papers/amd-cdna2-white-paper.pdf> Figure 1b
–Block diagram of the AMD Instinct™ MI200 multi-chip module (AMD Instinct™ MI250/MI250X) in the OAM form factor accelerator which comprise two Graphics Compute Dies (GCD) as illustrated.

GPU Structure – AMD MI200



-  Graphics Compute Die (GCD)
-  Compute Engine (CE)
-  Compute Unit (CU)

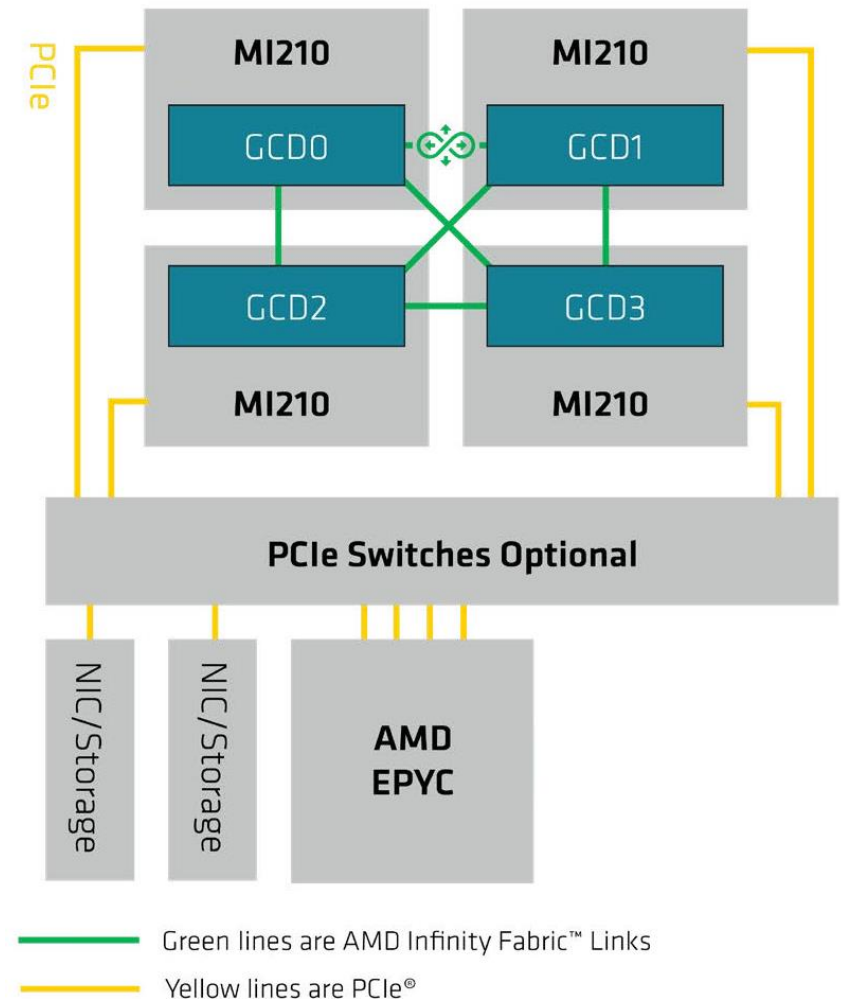
GPU Structure – ARCHER2 (AMD MI210)

4 compute nodes - each with:

- 4x MI210 GPUs
 - Each with one Graphics Compute Die
 - 104 compute units
 - 64 GB HBM2e Memory
- 1x AMD EPYC 7543P (Milan) CPU
 - 32 core @ 2.8 GHz
 - 512 GiB host memory

Documentation:

<https://docs.archer2.ac.uk/user-guide/gpu/>



Adapted from <https://www.amd.com/content/dam/amd/en/documents/instinct-business-docs/white-papers/amd-cdna2-white-paper.pdf> Figure 2e – Block diagram of a flagship HPC/AI server node built using the AMD Instinct™ MI210 accelerators in a quad GPU hive with direct connect xGMI bridge boards and AMD EPYC™ processor

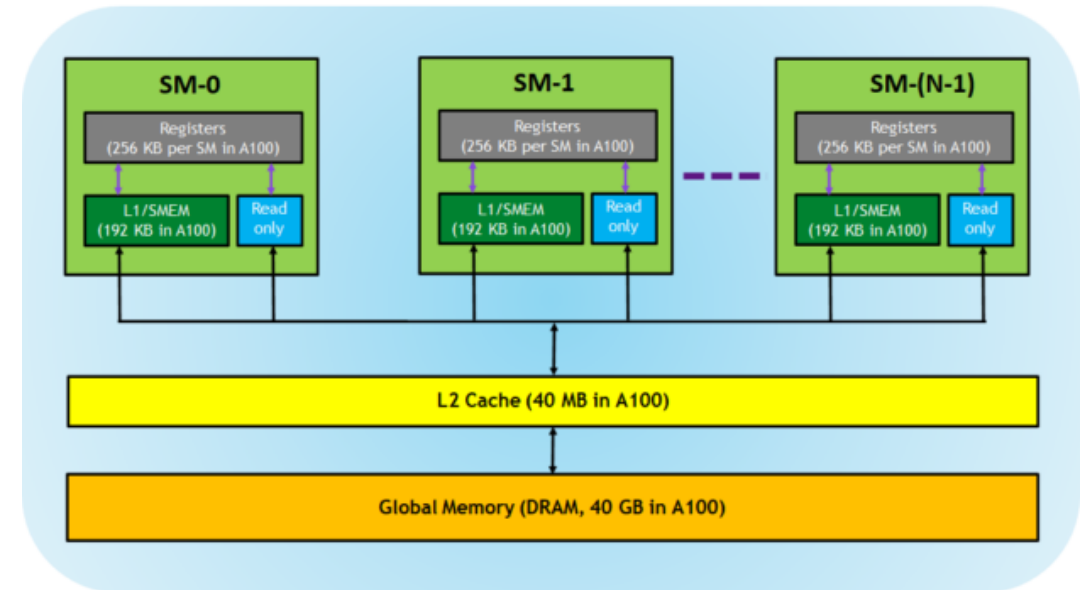
Threads, blocks, and warps

- **Thread** – item of work (i.e. a data point)
 - a thread is executed by a CUDA Core (Nvidia) or Stream Processor (AMD)
- **Block (Nvidia)/Workgroup (AMD)** - collection of threads
- Blocks/workgroups are assigned to SMs (Nvidia) or CUs (AMD)
- Threads execute in warps (Nvidia – 32 threads) or wavefronts (AMD – 64 threads)

Memory Hierarchy

Registers:

- Private to each thread – used to store local variables and intermediate results.
- Each thread has access to a set number of registers.
- If a kernel requires too many registers, it will utilise a portion of (slower) global memory as a local memory cache/scratchpad.

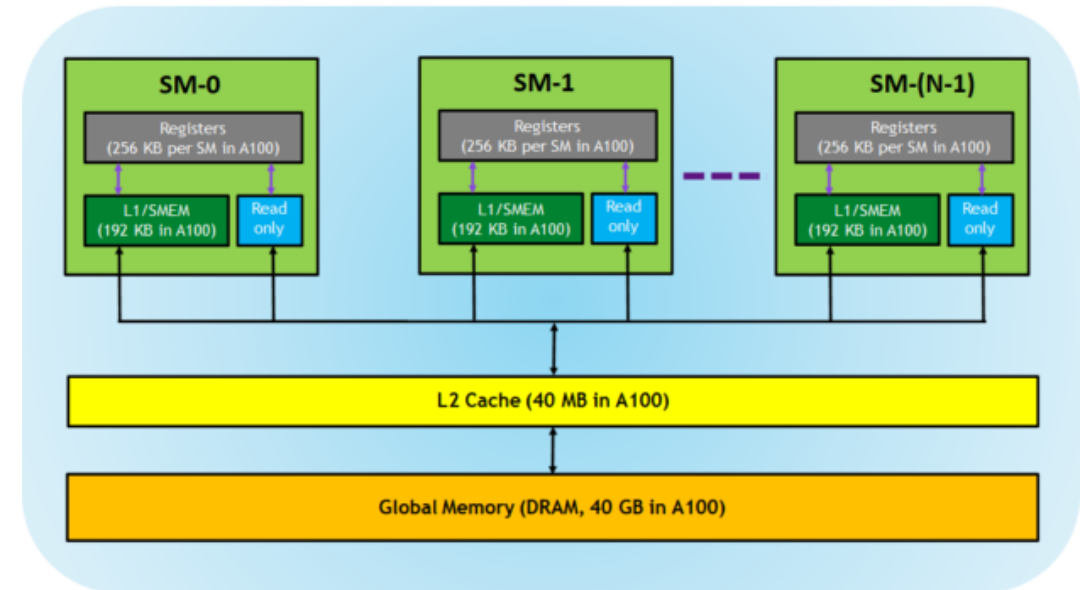


<https://developer.nvidia.com/blog/cuda-refresher-cuda-programming-model/> - Figure 4

Memory Hierarchy

L1 Cache/Shared Memory:

- Physical L1 cache resource is shared between blocks/workgroups on a given SM/CU.
- Shared memory is shared between threads in the same block/workgroup.

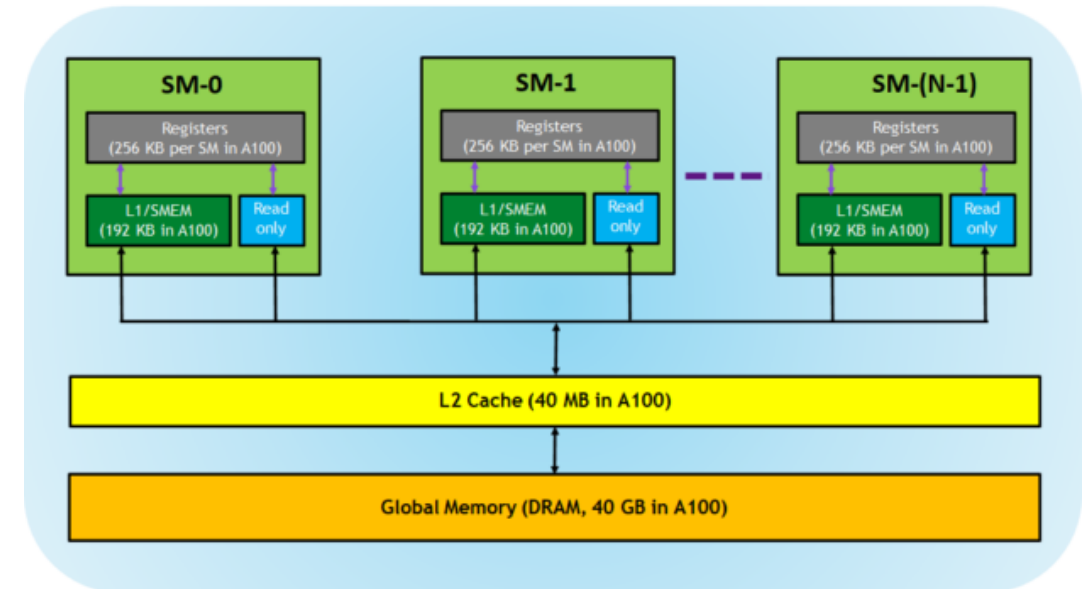


<https://developer.nvidia.com/blog/cuda-refresher-cuda-programming-model/> - Figure 4

Memory Hierarchy

Read-only memory:

- Each SM/CU has memory which is read-only to kernel code.
- It may be used as an instruction cache, constant memory, texture memory, RO cache, etc.

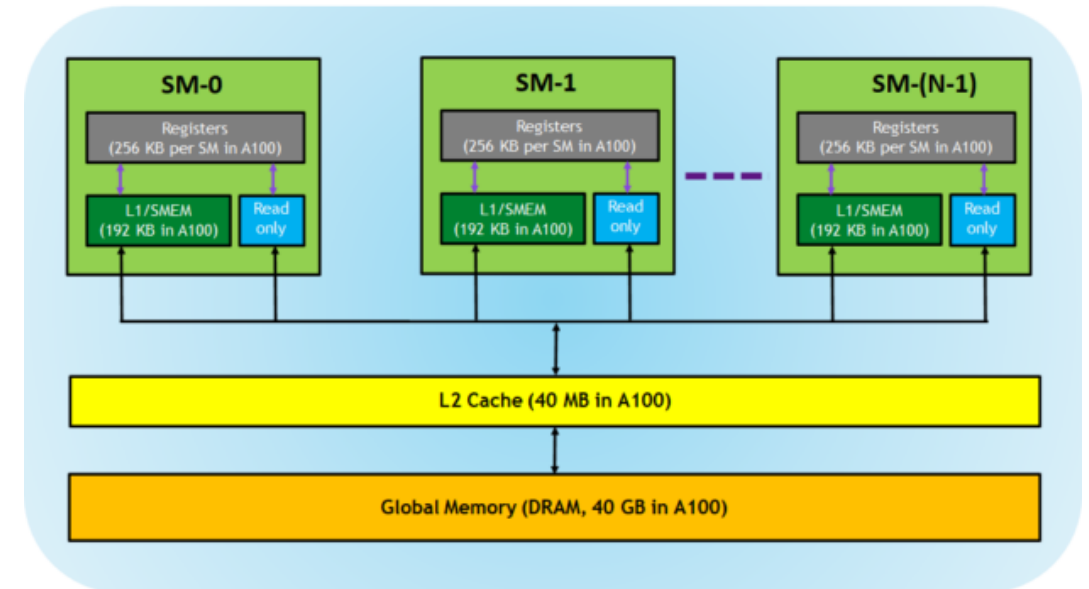


<https://developer.nvidia.com/blog/cuda-refresher-cuda-programming-model/> - Figure 4

Memory Hierarchy

L2 Cache:

- Shared across all SMs/CUs
- Hardware-managed cache that stores frequently accessed data to reduce memory latency

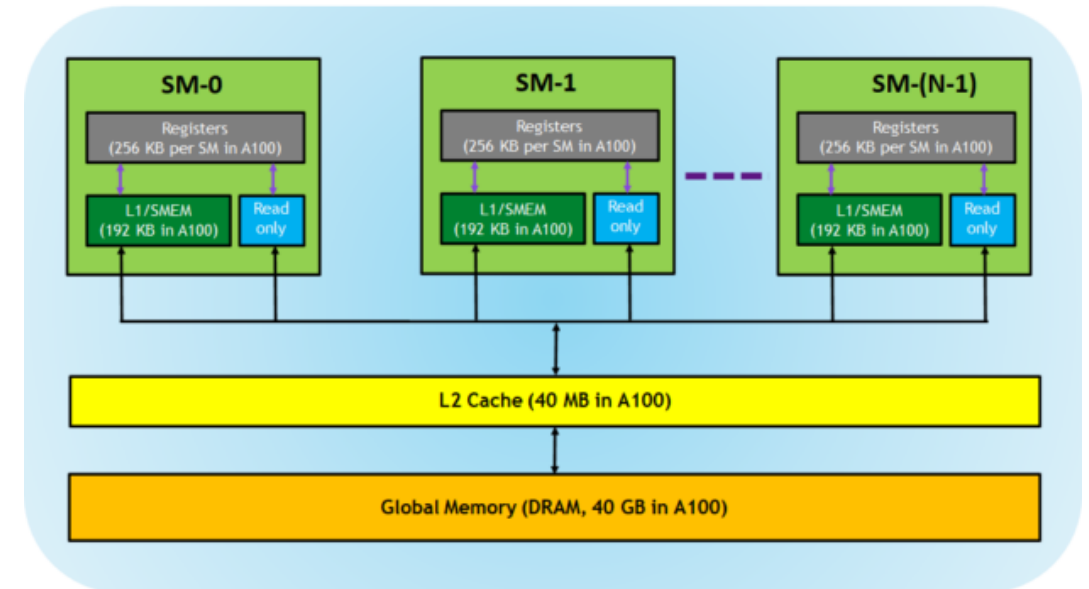


<https://developer.nvidia.com/blog/cuda-refresher-cuda-programming-model/> - Figure 4

Memory Hierarchy

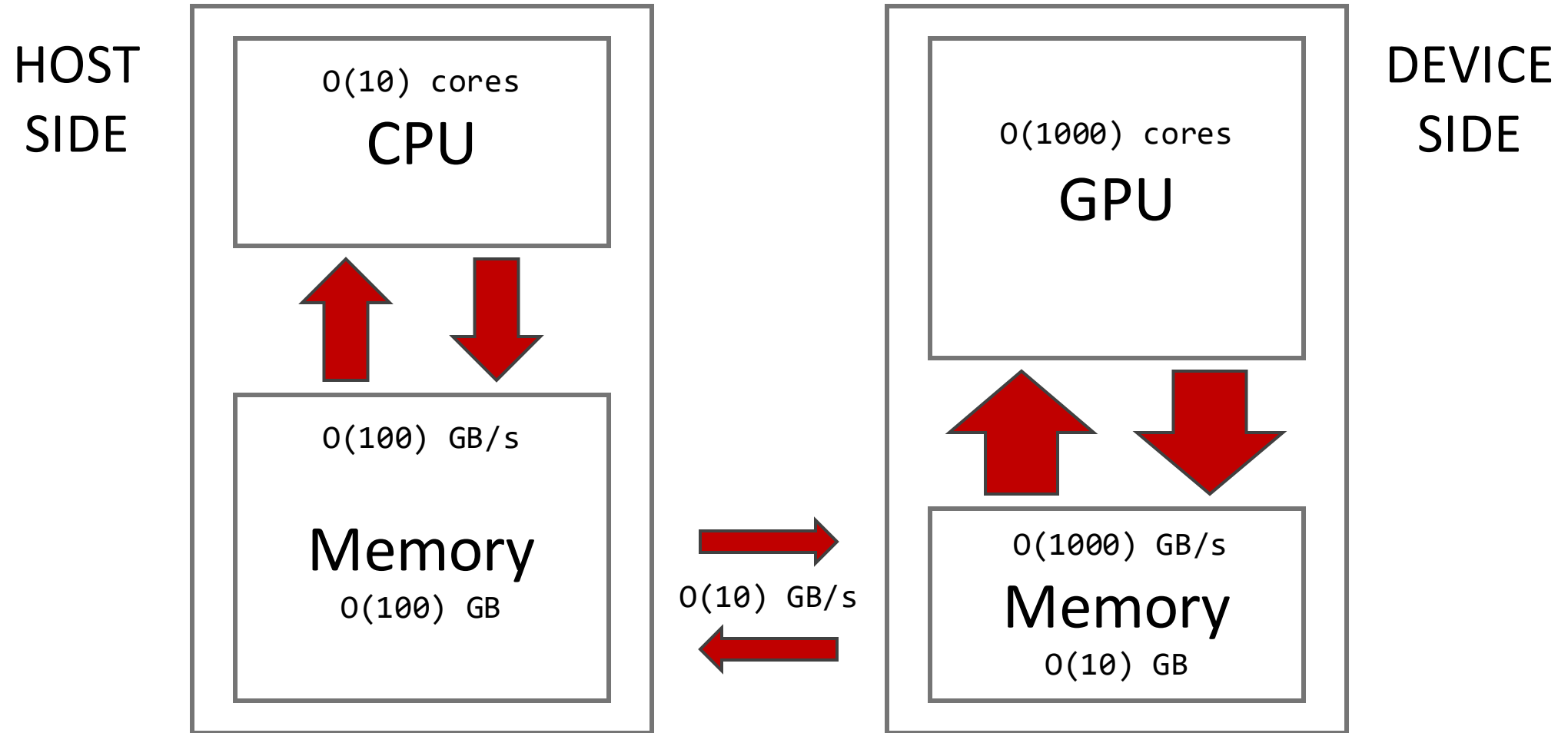
Global Memory

- Accessible by all threads, but access is relatively slow
- Primary storage for input data, output data, and global constants

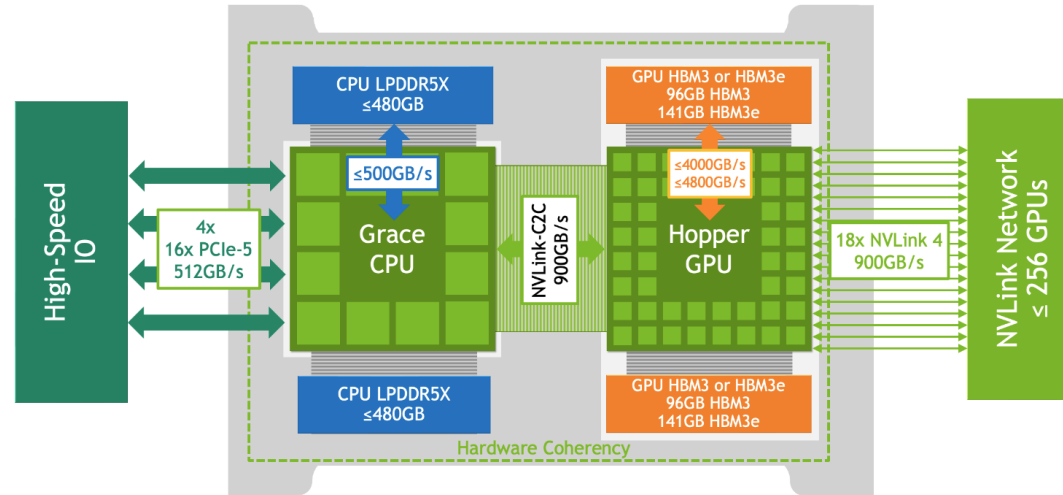


<https://developer.nvidia.com/blog/cuda-refresher-cuda-programming-model/> - Figure 4

Host Device Picture



Unified Memory – Gracehopper (NVIDIA)



Have separate CPU and GPU memory, but share an address space

Whether data is stored on the CPU or GPU will therefore influence access time

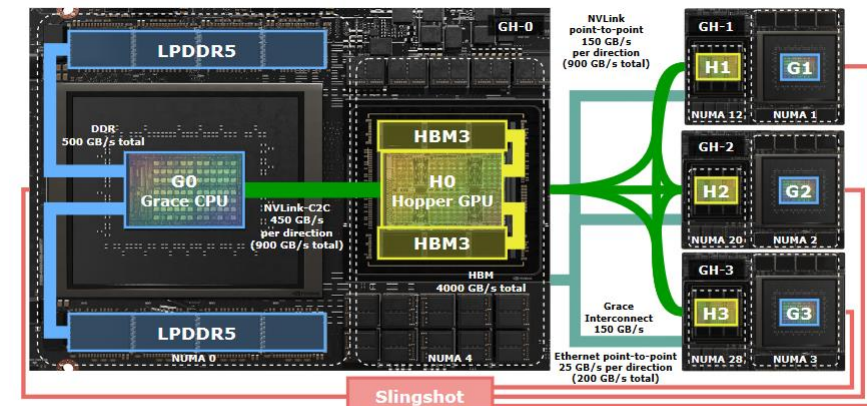
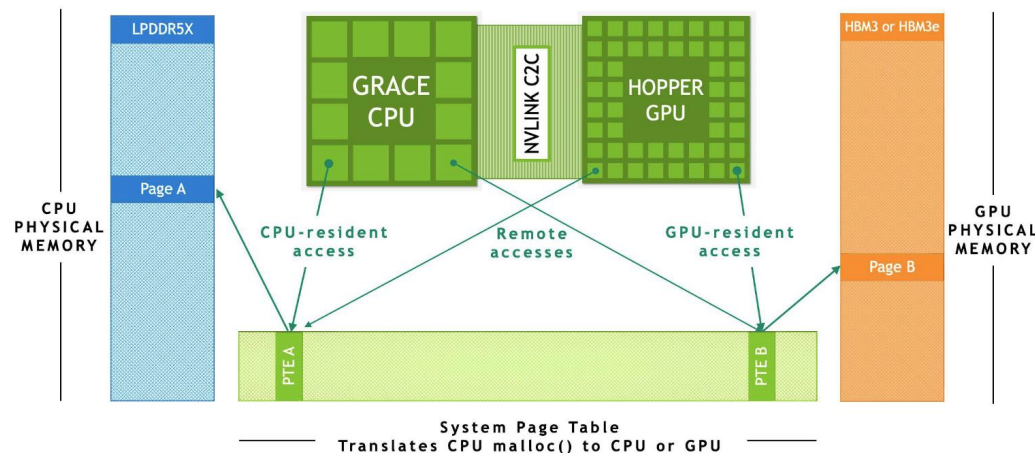
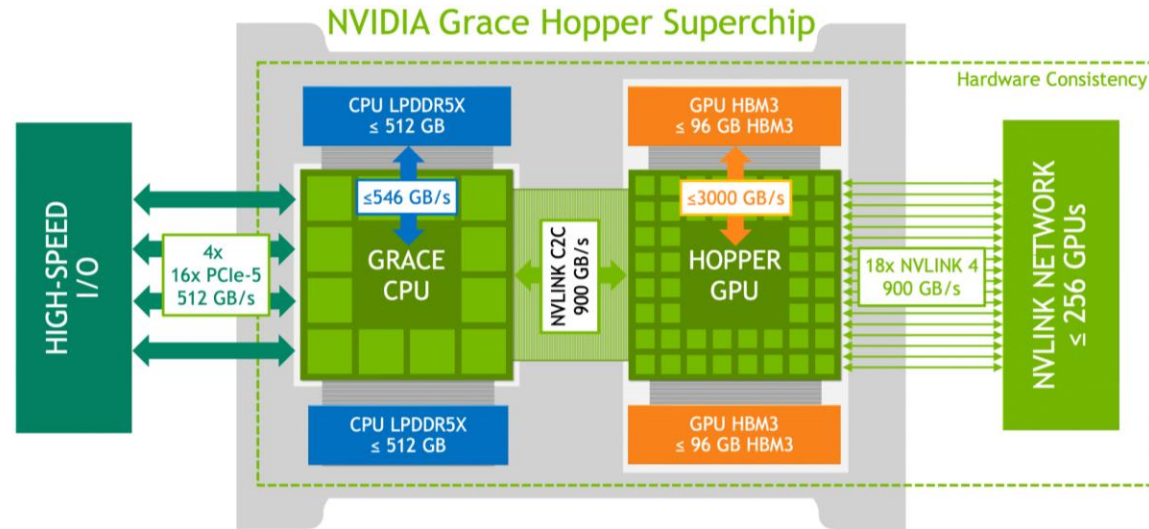


Fig. 1: Architecture of the Quad GH200 node of the Alps supercomputer. Every node is composed of four GH200 fully connected using NVLink and a cache coherent interconnect. Every GH200 is connected to a Slingshot network through a separate NIC.

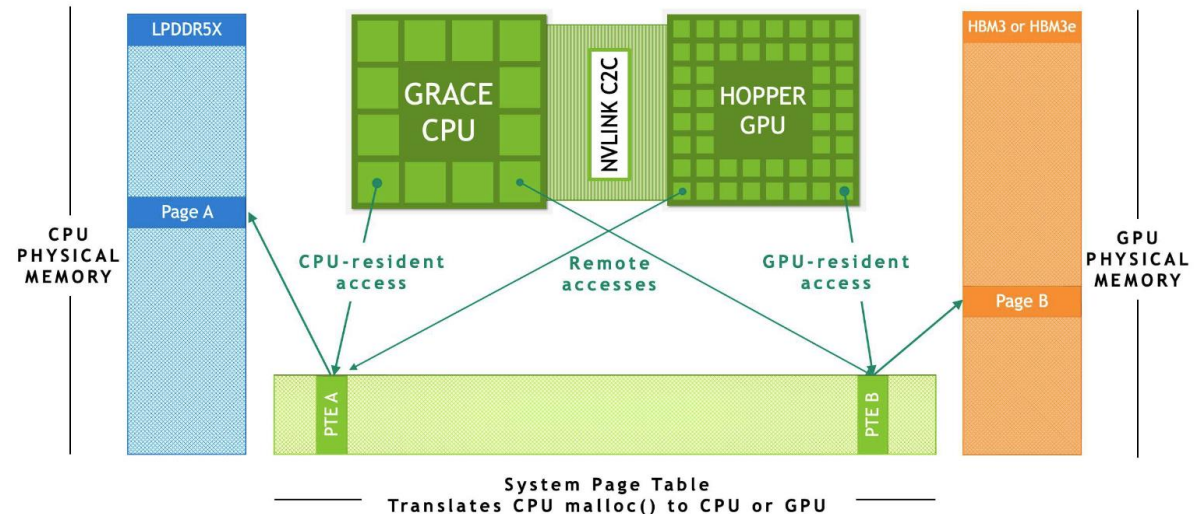
- New 'Superchips' or APUs (Advanced Processing Units) have unified memory between the GPU and CPU.
- No longer need to move data between host and device.
- However!
 - Does not guarantee equal latency or bandwidth across the whole memory space.
 - Location of your data (i.e. host or device) is still important.

Unified Memory – Gracehopper (NVIDIA)

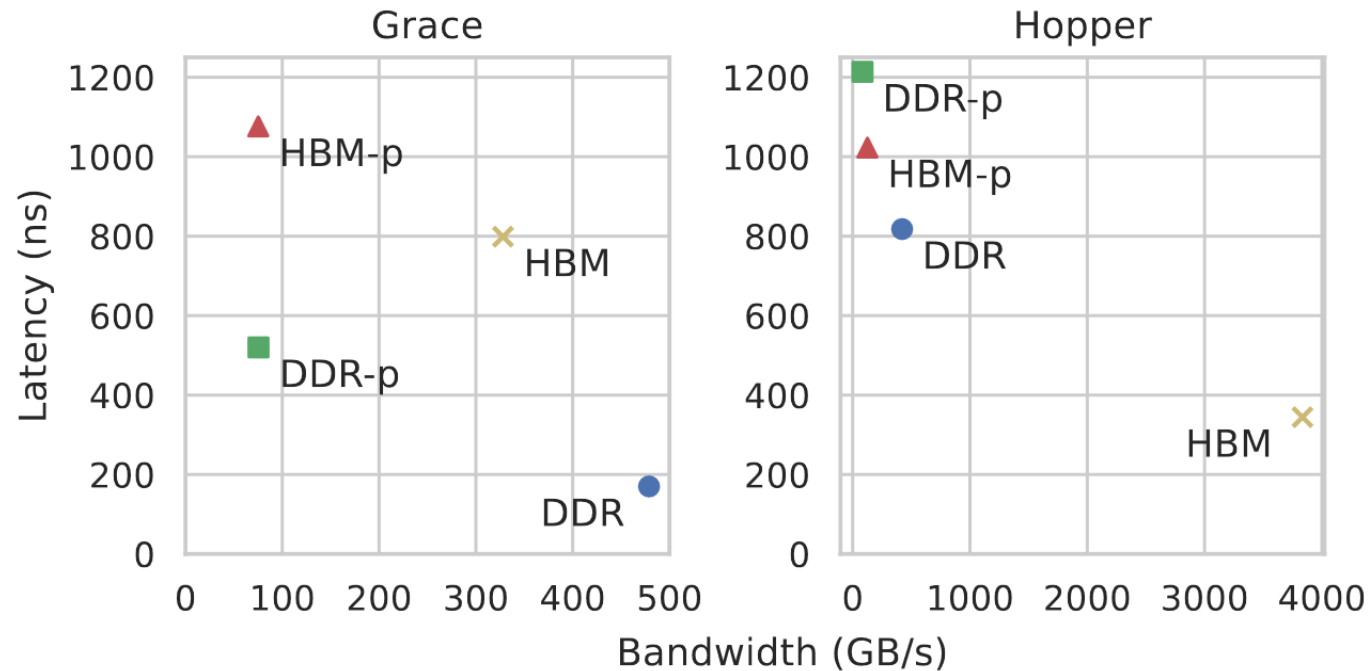


NVIDIA GH200 Grace Hopper Superchip combines a Grace CPU and Hopper GPU

System page table translates from CPU -> GPU and GPU -> CPU address spaces



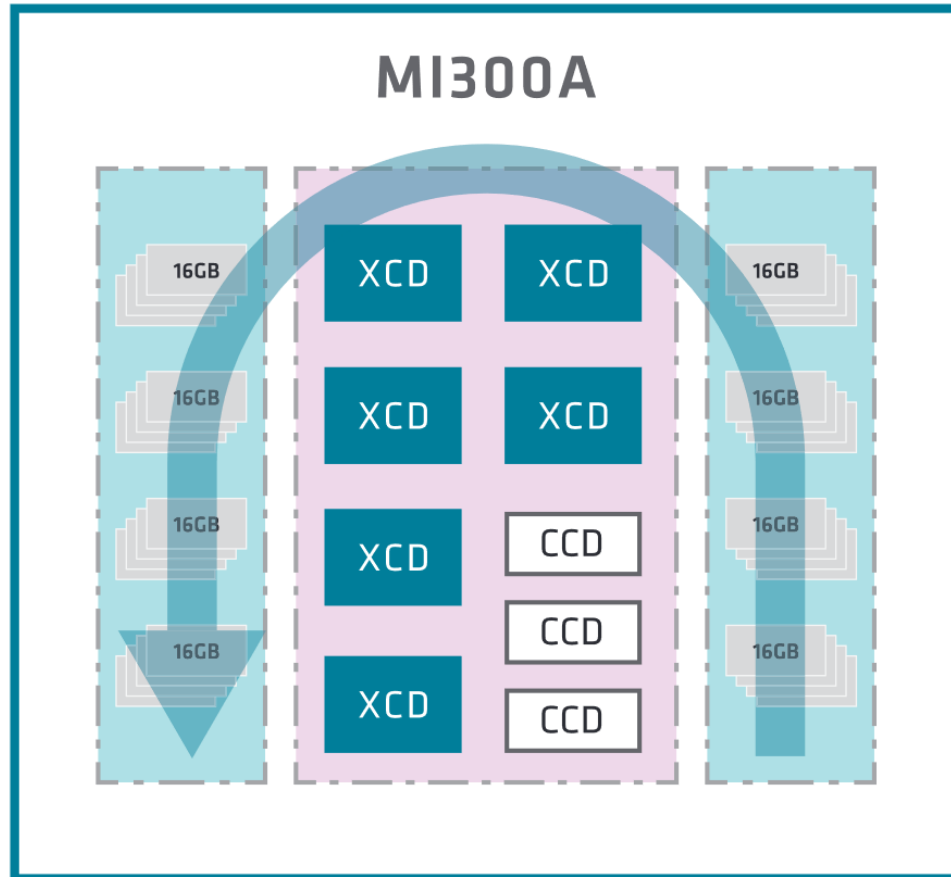
Unified Memory – Gracehopper (NVIDIA)



Maximum bandwidth plotted against access latency achieved by Grace (left) and Hopper (right) to different memories of the system. The suffix "-p" indicates memory on a peer GH200.

Fusco, L., Khalilov, M., Chrapek, M., Chukkapalli, G., Schulthess, T., & Hoefler, T. (2024, August 26). Understanding Data Movement in Tightly Coupled Heterogeneous Systems: A Case Study with the Grace Hopper Superchip. arXiv:2408.11556v2 [cs.DC]. doi: <https://doi.org/10.48550/arXiv.2408.11556>

Unified Memory – MI300A (AMD)



XCD - Accelerator Complex Dies

CCD - CPU Complex Dies

**SOCKET PHYSICAL
MEMORY MAP**



Low address

High address

Unified Memory – MI300A (AMD)



- 128GB unified HBM3 memory
- Unlike GH200, GPU and CPU memory is in the same physical location.
- Exact memory layout is unclear:
 - Most places claim 128GB of HBM3 memory.
 - But white paper mentions 128 GiB of DRAM interleaved between HBM stacks: switch stack every 4KiB through physical memory space.
- Theoretical bandwidth:
 - 384 GB/s peer-to-peer
 - 5.3 TB/s on-package peak throughput
- Likely still latency and bandwidth differences between CPU and GPU chiplets.

Summary: Key Concepts

- Potentially separate CPU and GPU address spaces
 - very high bandwidth between GPU and memory
- Processing power comes from many thousands of CUDA cores (NVIDIA) / Stream Processors (AMD)
 - each is a separate thread
- Threads operate in a SIMD / vector fashion
 - 32-thread warps (NVIDIA) or 64-thread wavefronts (AMD)